

The River Answers Back: Evidence on the Table

河流的回应：摆上桌面的证据

Theme: 环境、自然与可持续发展 · New: 44 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 44/6, 127

English Story

The evidence meeting was held in a **cottage upstairs** from the field station, in a room with a **rug**, a **cupboard**, and a **bathroom** nobody had cleaned. “This is a **story** about **moisture**, not about politics,” the hydrologist said. “**Nothing on** this table was measured in a **theater**.”

The **belief** in the old model had a **theatrical** quality: an **angel** of a forecast, a **handful** of statistics, and an **insect** of a detail that everyone ignored. An **airplane** passed overhead; **downstairs**, a **dolphin on** a poster watched the room.

The **exterior** of the argument was **oily** and **wavy**, like a **waterproof** sheet. A **monkey** in a cage, a **goat on** a rope, and a **pistol** in a drawer were, in the report, **mere** illustrations. “Put the two together,” Maya said, “and you have the **emptiness** of a **takeoff** without a runway.”

The **sailing** club had kept a **boiler** and a **dryer** in the same **cupboard** as their records, and the records had survived. “**Watertight**, not waterproof,” the boatman said. “That is the difference between a claim and a fact.” A **crush** of photographs lay on the table, each one **wavy** with damp.

The **fragmentary** evidence was enough for one conclusion: the district needed a **skyscraper** of data reduced to a **mouthful** of truth. Two of the five gauges were off by almost four per cent, and a **centigrade** reading from the north bank had been taken while the water was still rising.

“We do not need **nudity** of detail,” Lin said. “We need a **hairy**, awkward, exact account of what happened on the night of the flood.” The meeting ended with a single page, and the page included the river’s own answer. **Nothing on** the table was **mere** decoration: a **handful** of statistics from the **upstairs** room, a **belief** written on the **exterior** of the **cottage**, and an **oily wavy** record from the **sailing** club. An **airplane**, a **dolphin**, a **monkey**, an **insect**: the city’s icons had **nothing** to do with **moisture**, and the **emptiness** of the report was the **emptiness** of a **takeoff** without a runway. The **dryer**, the **boiler**, and the **rug** were all on the list. Almost every sentence in the file had one **statistic** behind it: an **eyebrow** raised, a **woollen rug**, and a record kept **ashore**. Four of the five items on the shelf were probably included by mistake, and the start of the action was to put them off the table while the need for **moisture** data stayed on it. There was no talk of a view from the tower, or of the water as scenery. The radio gave a pop and went quiet; downstream, past the **toilet**, an **apartment** block stood empty.

中文翻译

证据会议开在野外站楼上的一个小屋里，房间里有一块小地毯、一个碗柜，以及一间没人打扫过的浴室。“这是一个关于水分的故事，不是关于政治的故事，”水文学家说，“这张桌子上没有任何东西是在戏院里测量出来的。”

对旧模型的信念带有一种戏剧性：一位天使般的预报、一把统计数字，以及一个所有人都忽略的昆虫般的细节。一架飞机从头顶飞过；楼下，海报上的一只海豚看着这间屋子。

这场论证的表面是油滑而起伏的，像一张防水布。笼子里的一只猴子、绳子上的一只山羊，以及抽屉里的一把手枪，在报告里都只是单纯的插图。“把这两样放在一起看，”曼雅说，“你就得到了没有跑道的起飞的虚空。”

帆船俱乐部把一台锅炉和一台烘干机与他们的记录放在同一个碗柜里，而记录保存了下来。“水密，不是防水，”船夫说，“这就是主张与事实之间的区别。”桌上摊着一堆照片，每一张都因潮湿而起伏不平。

这些碎片式的证据足以得出一个结论：这个地区需要把一座摩天大楼的数据缩减成一口真相。五台水位计中有两台偏差接近百分之四，而北岸的一个摄氏读数是在水位还在上涨时测的。

“我们不需要细节的裸露，”林伟说，“我们需要一份多毛的、笨拙的、精确的记录，讲清洪水那一夜到底发生了什么。”会议以一页纸结束，而那一页里包含了河流自己的回答。桌上没有任何东西只是装饰：楼上房间里的一把统计数字、写在村舍外墙上的一种信念，以及帆船俱乐部一份油滑起伏的记录。一架飞机、一只海豚、一只猴子、一只昆虫：这座城市的图标与水分毫无关系，而报告的空洞，就是一场没有跑道的起飞的空洞。烘干机、锅炉和地毯都在清单上。文件里几乎每一句话背后都有一个统计数字：一条扬起的眉毛、一块羊毛地毯，以及一份在岸上保存的记录。架子上的五样东西里有四样大概是误放进去的，而行动的第一步就是把它们从桌上拿开，同时把对水分数据的需要留在桌上。没有人谈到从塔上看到的景色，也没有人把水当作风景。收音机发出一声爆响就安静了；下游，过了厕所，一排公寓空着。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
story 'stɔ:ri POS: n	n. 故事, 小说, 传奇, 描述, 阅历, 经历, 层 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a piece of fiction that narrates a chain of related events
nothing 'nʌθɪŋ POS: n	n. 无, 不关紧要之事, 零; adv. 毫不, 决不; interj. 什么也没有, 无 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a quantity of no importance; r. in no respect; to no degree
apartment ə'pɑ:t'ment POS: n	n. 房间, 公寓 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a suite of rooms usually on one floor of an apartment house
belief bi'li:f POS: n	n. 信念, 相信, 信仰 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any cognitive content held as true
theater 'θiətə POS: n	n. 戏院, 电影院, 剧场, 全体观众, 戏剧, 戏剧效果, 阶梯式讲堂, 场所 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a building where theatrical performances or motion-picture shows can be presented
cottage 'kɒtɪdʒ POS: n	n. 小屋, 茅舍 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a small house with a single story
bathroom 'bɑ:θru:m POS: n	n. 浴室, 厕所 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a room (as in a residence) containing a bathtub or shower and usually a washbasin and toilet
mere miə POS: n	n. 小湖, 池塘; a. 仅仅的, 只不过的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a small pond of standing water; s. being nothing more than specified
upstairs 'ʌp'steəz POS: a	a. 楼上的; adv. 在楼上, 向楼上, 处于更高地位; n. 楼层 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the part of a building above the ground floor; a. on or of upper floors of a building; r. on a floor above; r...
handful 'hændful POS: n	n. 少数, 一把, 棘手事 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a small number or amount; n. the quantity that can be held in the hand
angel 'eɪndʒəl POS: n	n. 天使, 守护神, 善人 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. spiritual being attendant upon God; n. invests in a theatrical production; n. the highest waterfall; has mor...
insect 'ɪnsekt POS: n	n. 昆虫, 卑鄙的人; [医] 昆虫 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. small air-breathing arthropod
airplane 'eəpleɪn POS: n	n. 飞机; [机] 飞机 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an aircraft that has a fixed wing and is powered by propellers or jets
toilet 'tɔɪlɪt POS: n	n. 厕所, 梳妆; vi. 梳妆, 打扮, 上厕所; vt. 给...梳妆打扮 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a room or building equipped with one or more toilets; n. a plumbing fixture for defecation and urination; n. ...
cupboard 'kʌpbɔ:d POS: n	n. 食橱, 碗柜, 餐具柜 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a small room (or recess) or cabinet used for storage space
downstairs 'daʊn'steəz POS: n	n. 楼下; a. 楼下的; adv. 在楼下 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. on or of lower floors of a building; r. on a floor below
dolphin 'dɒlfɪn POS: n	n. 海豚 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any of various small toothed whales with a beaklike snout; larger than porpoises
crush krʌʃ POS: n	n. 压碎, 粉碎, 群众, 迷恋; vt. 压破, 征服, 塞, 弄皱, 榨出; vi. 被压碎, 起皱, 挤 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a dense crowd of people; n. the act of crushing; v. break into small pieces; v. humiliate or depress complete...
eyebrow 'aɪbraʊ POS: n	n. 眉毛; [医] 眉 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the arch of hair above each eye
monkey 'mʌŋki POS: n	n. 猴子, 猿, 打桩锤; vi. 淘气, 胡闹; vt. 嘲弄 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any of various long-tailed primates (excluding the prosimians)
rug rʌɡ POS: n	n. 小块地毯, 揭露某人 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)
goat geʊt POS: n	n. 山羊, 替罪羊, 色鬼 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any of numerous agile ruminants related to sheep but having a beard and straight horns
pistol 'pɪstl POS: n	n. 手枪, 信号枪; vt. 以手枪杀死(或伤害) Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a firearm that is held and fired with one hand
moisture 'moɪstʃə POS: n	n. 湿气, 水分, 降雨; [化] 含水量; 含湿量 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. wetness caused by water

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
sailing 'seilɪŋ POS: n	n. 航行, 航海术, 启航; a. 航行的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. riding in a sailboat; n. the departure of a vessel from a port
boiler 'bɔɪlə POS: n	n. 煮器, 汽锅, 锅炉; [化] 锅炉 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. sealed vessel where water is converted to steam
theatrical θi'ætrɪkl POS: a	a. 剧场的, 夸张的, 戏剧性的; n. 戏剧演出 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of or relating to the theater; a. suited to or characteristic of the stage or theater
ashore ə'ʃɔː POS: adv	adv. 向岸, 在岸上 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. towards the shore from the water
woollen 'wʊlɪn POS: n	n. 毛织品; a. 羊毛制的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a fabric made from the hair of sheep; a of or related to or made of wool
exterior ɪk'stɪəriə POS: n	n. 外部, 表面, 外貌; a. 外部的, 外在的, 表面的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. situated in or suitable for the outdoors or outside of a building
mouthful 'maʊθfʊl POS: n	n. 一口, 满口 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the quantity that can be held in the mouth
emptiness 'emptɪnɪs POS: n	n. 空虚, 无知 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the state of containing nothing; n. having an empty stomach
dryer 'draɪə POS: n	n. 干衣机, 干燥剂; [化] 干燥剂; 催干剂; 干燥器; 干燥设备; 烘箱 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an appliance that removes moisture
statistic ste'tɪstɪk POS: n	n. 统计量; a. 统计的, 统计学的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a datum that can be represented numerically
hairy 'heəri POS: a	a. 多毛的, 毛状的, 长毛的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. having or covered with hair; s. hazardous and frightening
waterproof 'wɒtəpruːf POS: n	n. 防水材料; a. 不透水的, 防水的; vt. 使防水 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any fabric impervious to water; v. make watertight
takeoff 'teɪkɒːf POS: n	n. 起飞 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a departure; especially of airplanes; n. the initial ascent of an airplane as it becomes airborne
skyscraper 'skaɪskreɪpə POS: n	n. 摩天楼, 三角形天帆 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a very tall building with many stories
oily 'ɔɪli POS: a	a. 油的, 油滑的, 油嘴的; [化] 油的; 含油的; 油性的; 油质的; 多油的; 油腻的; 油滑的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. coated or covered with oil
wavy 'weɪvi POS: a	a. 有波浪的, 多浪的, 波浪状的, 波动的, 不稳定的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. (of hair) having waves
nudity 'njuːdɪti POS: n	n. 裸露, 裸露物, 裸体像 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n the state of being without clothing or covering of any kind
fragmentary 'fræɡməntəri POS: a	a. 碎片的, 碎屑的, 片断的, 断片的, 碎块的, 不完全的, 不连续的, 不完整的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s consisting of small disconnected parts
watertight 'wɒtətaɪt POS: a	a. 不透水的, 不漏水的, 无懈可击的; [化] 不透水的; 不漏水的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. not allowing water to pass in or out
centigrade 'sentɪɡreɪd POS: a	a. 百分度的, 摄氏的; [医] 百分度 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of or relating to a temperature scale on which the freezing point of water is 0 degrees and the boiling po...